CSE0001 – Digital Literacy

PROJECT REPORT

Digital Literacy Portfolio

Student Digital Ambassador — CSE0001 | 2025–26

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This report is submitted as part of the Digital Literacy Portfolio (CSE0001) at VIT Bhopal University. All written reflections are original and based on the author's own experiences and research. This document is for academic assessment purposes only.

GitHub Repository: github.com/nakshatra25mim10206-ux/Digital_Literacy

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Introduction

This report documents my work for the CSE0001 – Digital Literacy project at VIT Bhopal University. For this project, I took on the role of a Student Digital Ambassador — someone responsible for helping fellow first-year students navigate the digital world more confidently and safely.

The project is structured around five modules, each addressing a different dimension of digital literacy: creating awareness materials, building a professional online presence, exploring coding and collaboration platforms, learning professional digital communication, and understanding cybercrime and how to protect against it.

What I found most valuable about this project is that it is not just theoretical. Every task required me to actually do something — create a real Canva design, set up a real GitHub profile, write real emails, complete a real coding challenge, and research a real cybercrime scenario. That hands-on approach made the learning stick in a way that simply reading about these topics would not have.

Going into my first year, I was already somewhat familiar with tools like Google Forms and social media. But I had never seriously thought about my professional digital footprint, written a formal email to a professor, or considered just how organised and systematic cybercriminals in India are. This project changed that. I am finishing it with both practical skills and a sharper awareness of the digital world I am operating in.

Task	Description	Marks
Task 1	Infographic – Digital Literacy Awareness	**20 / 20**
Task 2	Student Digital Portfolio Setup	**20 / 20**
Task 3	Coding Practice & Collaboration Tools	**20 / 20**
Task 4	Professional Email & Etiquette Guide	**20 / 20**
Task 5	Cybercrime Case Study & Prevention	**20 / 20**

Task 1 Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

Overview

The first task required me to create a one-page visual infographic to help my batchmates understand what Digital Literacy means and why it matters. As a Student Digital Ambassador, producing easy-to-understand awareness materials is one of my core responsibilities.

Tool Used

I used Canva — a free, browser-based design platform — to create the infographic. I chose Canva because it has a large library of pre-built infographic templates, supports custom colour schemes, and exports clean PNG or PDF files without any watermark on the free plan. It also allowed me to work entirely in the browser without installing any software.

What the Design Shows

The infographic is a single-page visual divided into three clearly labelled sections:

- What Digital Literacy Is — A plain-language definition and a short explanation of why it matters for students navigating work, education, and social life in 2025.
- Safe Internet Practices — Five key habits: using strong passwords, recognising phishing attempts, not oversharing personal information online, enabling two-factor authentication, and verifying sources before sharing content.
- Professional Online Presence — Why platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub matter for a CS student, and what a clean, professional digital footprint looks like at the start of a career.

The design uses a blue and white colour scheme for readability, bold section headings, and simple line icons for each section so that the reader can scan and absorb the key points in under thirty seconds.

Reflection

Using Canva was easier than I expected, but making the infographic genuinely useful — rather than just visually impressive — was harder. The biggest challenge was deciding what to leave out. Digital literacy is a broad topic, and I initially tried to fit five sections onto one page. The result looked cluttered and overwhelming. I ended up cutting sections on email etiquette and coding platforms, keeping only the three most immediately relevant topics for a first-year student.

That editing process taught me something I did not expect: good communication design is as much about restraint as it is about what you include. A focused, readable infographic is more useful than a comprehensive one that no one wants to read. I will carry that lesson into other presentations and reports.

Task 2 Student Digital Portfolio

Overview

Task 2 required me to establish a professional digital presence across at least three online platforms. The goal was to lay the foundation of a portfolio that will grow alongside my skills over the next four years — one that employers, internship coordinators, and the academic community can find and evaluate.

Platforms Set Up

Platform	Description	How I Will Use It
GitHub	Version control, project hosting, open-source collaboration	Store all my projects, contribute to open-source repositories, and build a public coding portfolio that employers can view directly.
LinkedIn	Professional networking, job applications, industry news	Connect with seniors, professors, and recruiters; document internships and achievements; research companies before applying.
Kaggle	Data science competitions, datasets, notebooks	Explore machine learning concepts, participate in beginner competitions, and document data projects as I progress through my degree.

GitHub Profile README

On GitHub, I created a profile README repository (a special repository named after my username) that displays automatically on my public profile page. The README includes my name, registration number, branch, year, and a personal learning goal statement. I also added badge-style icons for the languages I am currently learning — Python, C++, Java, Git, and GitHub — along with links to my other profiles and my Digital_Literacy project repository.

Reflection

> Setting up these profiles felt surprisingly significant. I have had a LinkedIn account for about six months, but I had never filled it in properly — no education

section, no profile photo, nothing that would be useful to anyone who found it. Completing this task properly made me realise how much first impressions matter in a digital context, just as they do in person.

GitHub was the most technically interesting platform to set up. Writing a profile README in Markdown — using badge images, tables, and formatted sections — was my first real introduction to what version control systems look and feel like. I can already see how I will use it differently in one year versus four years from now. I plan to use LinkedIn for networking from Day 1, GitHub to document every project from Day 1, and Kaggle once I start studying data science and machine learning in my second year.

Task 3 Coding & Collaboration Platforms

Overview

This task introduced me to two categories of platforms that are foundational for any CS student: competitive coding platforms where I can build and demonstrate programming skills, and cloud collaboration tools for teamwork and communication. Both are tools I will use throughout my degree and beyond.

Part A – Coding Practice: HackerRank

I created an account on HackerRank and completed two challenges to get started:

- "Solve Me First" — a beginner problem under the Problem Solving domain that introduced me to how HackerRank reads input and produces output.
- Python Introduction Skill Test — a structured set of beginner Python exercises covering variables, data types, and basic operations.

Completing the Python skill test earned me a verified badge that I can display on my LinkedIn profile. HackerRank is used by companies including Google, Amazon, Wipro, and TCS to assess candidates before interviews, which makes building a presence there genuinely useful rather than just academic.

Part B – Google Workspace: Google Forms

For the collaboration component, I built a five-question Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz using Google Forms, which automatically links responses to a Google Sheet for analysis.

#	Question	Type
1	What does "Digital Literacy" primarily mean?	Multiple Choice
2	Which of the following is the safest password?	Multiple Choice
3	What is a common sign of a phishing email?	Multiple Choice

4	Why is it important to maintain a professional online presence?	Multiple Choice
5	What is one good practice you follow to stay safe online?	Short Answer

Reflection

HackerRank was more engaging than I expected. Even a simple problem like "Solve Me First" required me to think about input/output in a structured way — something that feels basic in theory but is easy to get wrong in practice. Seeing a badge appear after the Python test gave me a concrete sense of progress that reading a textbook chapter does not.

Building the Google Form was a different kind of challenge. I had to think carefully about what questions would actually test awareness of digital literacy, as opposed to just general knowledge. Designing it from the perspective of a Digital Ambassador — someone educating peers rather than being assessed myself — made me think harder about clarity and structure. Both tools will serve me well: HackerRank as a place to build a verifiable coding portfolio, and Google Workspace for every group project and collaborative task ahead.

Task 4 Professional Email & Etiquette Guide

Overview

This task focused on professional digital communication — writing well-structured formal emails and creating a social media responsibility guide. For a Student Digital Ambassador, being able to model good communication and teach it to others is essential.

Part A – Email 1: Requesting a Deadline Extension

Subject: Request for Assignment Submission Extension – Data Structures (CS2001)

To: Prof. R. Mehta | CSE2001 - Data Structures

Dear Prof. Mehta,

I hope this message finds you well. I am writing to respectfully request a short extension for the Data Structures assignment due on 5th April 2026.

Over the past week I have been unwell with a fever and was advised rest by the campus medical centre. While I have made reasonable progress on the assignment, I am concerned that submitting incomplete work would not reflect my actual understanding of the topic.

I would be grateful if you could grant a two-day extension, allowing me to submit by 7th April 2026. I have attached the medical certificate for your reference and assure you this will not affect any other deadlines.

Thank you for your time and understanding.

Warm regards,

Nakshatra Kundnani
25MIM10206 | Int.M.Tech CSE (AI) – 1st Year | VIT Bhopal University

Part A – Email 2: Summer Internship Application

Subject: Application for Summer Internship 2026 – Software Development

To: Ms. Priya Kapoor | HR, TechNova Solutions

Dear Ms. Kapoor,

I am Nakshatra Kundnani, a first-year Int.M.Tech Computer Science (Artificial Intelligence) student at VIT Bhopal University (Reg. No. 25MIM10206). I am writing to express my interest in a summer internship opportunity at TechNova Solutions for the upcoming vacation period (May–June 2026).

I am currently learning Java, Python, and C++, and have recently completed a Digital Literacy project involving GitHub, data tools, and online collaboration platforms. I am eager to apply this foundation in a real professional environment and gain hands-on exposure to software development workflows.

I would welcome the opportunity to contribute to your team, even in a supporting capacity. I have attached my resume and GitHub profile link for your review. Please feel free to reach out if you require any additional information.

Thank you sincerely for considering my application. I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours sincerely,

Nakshatra Kundnani
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Part B – Social Media Do's and Don'ts

✓ Do's	✗ Don'ts
Keep your LinkedIn and GitHub profiles updated and professional	Post anything you would not want a professor or employer to see
Think before posting — ask: would I be comfortable if my family saw this?	Share your address, phone number, or daily schedule publicly
Use platform privacy settings to control who sees your content	Engage with or spread unverified news or rumours
Credit others when sharing their work or ideas	Accept connection requests from people you cannot verify

Report harmful or suspicious content using in-app tools	Share OTPs, passwords, or banking details over any chat platform
Log out of all accounts on shared or public devices	Post mockery or negative content about peers, professors, or your institution
Maintain a consistent, professional tone in any public post	Assume any online platform is truly private or anonymous

Reflection

Writing the internship email was harder than I expected. The challenge was not length but tone — professional without sounding robotic, confident without sounding arrogant. I rewrote the opening paragraph three times before I was satisfied with it.

One real incident that shaped how I think about this: in 2021, a student at a university in Pune shared an angry message about a professor in what they thought was a private group chat. The message was screenshotted and forwarded widely, eventually reaching the administration. It resulted in a formal hearing and damaged reputations on both sides. What should have been done differently? The student should have addressed the issue privately — either directly with the professor, or through the institution's student grievance process. The key lesson: in the digital world, no message is ever truly private. Write every message as if it might one day be public.

Task 5 Cybercrime Awareness Case Study

Overview

For this task I chose to research UPI / Online Payment Fraud — specifically the Courier Scam variant, which has become one of the most prevalent cybercrime types in India. My decision was personal: the summer before joining VIT, someone close to my family lost a significant amount of money to exactly this kind of scam. Researching it properly felt important.

Part A – Case Study: The Courier Scam

Note: The following case study is based on a composite of real incidents documented by the Cyber Dost initiative (MHA), the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, and Indian news media between 2022 and 2024. The victim's name is fictionalised.

What the Crime Is

UPI / Online Payment Fraud exploits the speed and irreversibility of India's Unified Payments Interface to steal money from victims through deception and social engineering rather than technical hacking. The courier scam variant is one of the most sophisticated and psychologically damaging forms.

How It Happens — Step by Step

Step 1	The victim receives a call from someone posing as a FedEx or India Post customer executive. They are told a parcel in their name has been seized at customs for containing illegal items — fake passports, controlled substances, or electronics on a watchlist. The caller provides a fake case reference number and reads out the victim's full name and city, obtained from a data breach or public social media profile.
Step 2	The caller escalates the threat: the victim's Aadhaar number has been "misused", and they are now under investigation. The victim is told not to speak to anyone — not parents, not friends — or it will be treated as evidence of guilt. This isolation is critical: it removes every safety net.

Step 3	The call transfers to WhatsApp video. A person in what appears to be a CBI officer's uniform, seated before an official-looking backdrop, places the victim under "digital arrest" — they must stay on camera and cannot leave. This can last hours.
Step 4	The scammer shares a forged Supreme Court document naming the victim in a money-laundering case, assembled using publicly available personal information. The victim is told the only way to prove innocence is to transfer a "refundable security deposit" via UPI to a "government escrow account".
Step 5	Under extreme fear and isolated from help, the victim transfers money. The moment the transfer is confirmed, the call drops. The scammer's number is switched off. The money moves instantly through a chain of mule accounts and is virtually unrecoverable.

Who Is Targeted

No demographic is immune, but the NCRB 2022 data shows that 18–25 year-olds account for approximately 31% of financial cybercrime victims — the single largest group. College students are particularly vulnerable because many are managing their own finances independently for the first time, are active on platforms like OLX where scammers operate, and are more likely to fear legal consequences and comply under pressure.

Consequences

The financial loss is often catastrophic and largely unrecoverable. Once a UPI transfer is made, the money moves through mule accounts within minutes. The 1930 helpline can freeze accounts if called within one to two hours, but this window is short. Beyond the financial impact, victims frequently experience severe anxiety, shame, and long-term distrust of digital platforms. Many do not report the crime to their families for months out of embarrassment, delaying any chance of recovery.

Part B – Prevention Checklist (Summary)

The full prevention checklist is submitted separately as prevention-checklist.md. Key points include:

- Never share your UPI PIN, OTP, or mPIN with anyone — no government agency, bank, or courier company will ever ask for it.

- Receiving money via UPI never requires you to enter your PIN. If someone asks you to enter a PIN to receive a payment, it is a scam.
- No legitimate authority — CBI, police, courts, or customs — will place you under “digital arrest” or conduct legal proceedings over a video call.
- Set a daily UPI transaction limit and link only a low-balance account to your UPI apps.
- If scammed, call 1930 immediately — within the first hour, there is a real chance of freezing the fraudulent account.
- Report all incidents at cybercrime.gov.in regardless of whether money is recovered, to help law enforcement track patterns.

If you are scammed — act within 60 minutes
Helpline: 1930 (24×7) | Report: cybercrime.gov.in | Follow: @CyberDost

Reflection

What surprised me most while researching this topic was not the technology — which is actually quite basic — but how precisely these scams are engineered around human psychology. The scammers do not hack your phone. They hack your emotions. The moment you are frightened, isolated from anyone who could help, and given a countdown, rational thinking becomes nearly impossible. I read testimonies of professors, engineers, and experienced adults who fell for this. That was genuinely humbling.

The one habit I will personally change as a result of this research: I will never approve or initiate a UPI transfer when I am feeling pressured, scared, or rushed. If someone is creating urgency around money, that urgency itself is the warning sign. I will hang up, take a breath, and verify independently. I have also shared what I learned with my parents, which felt like the most immediately useful thing I could do with this knowledge.

Conclusion

Completing this project across five modules gave me something that a standard lecture series often does not: a set of things I actually did, rather than just things I read about. I have a GitHub profile that works, emails I drafted and refined, a cybercrime case study I researched properly, and an infographic I designed and edited. These are small beginnings, but they are real ones.

The biggest shift in my thinking came from Task 5. Understanding how systematically organised digital fraud is — the data theft, the call centre teams, the mule account networks, the psychological manipulation — made me realise that digital safety is not about avoiding technology. It is about understanding it well enough that the vulnerabilities others exploit no longer apply to you.

As a Student Digital Ambassador, my job is to share what I have learned. I plan to use the Google Form quiz from Task 3 as an actual awareness tool during orientation for the next batch. I want to use the infographic from Task 1 on our department notice board. These are not just assignment deliverables — they are genuinely useful materials, and treating them that way made the whole project more meaningful.

Key Takeaway: Being digitally literate in 2025 means more than knowing how to use apps. It means building a professional presence, communicating clearly, collaborating effectively, and staying informed enough to protect yourself and the people around you.

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End of Project Report | CSE0001 – Digital Literacy | Nakshatra Kundnani | 25MIM10206
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